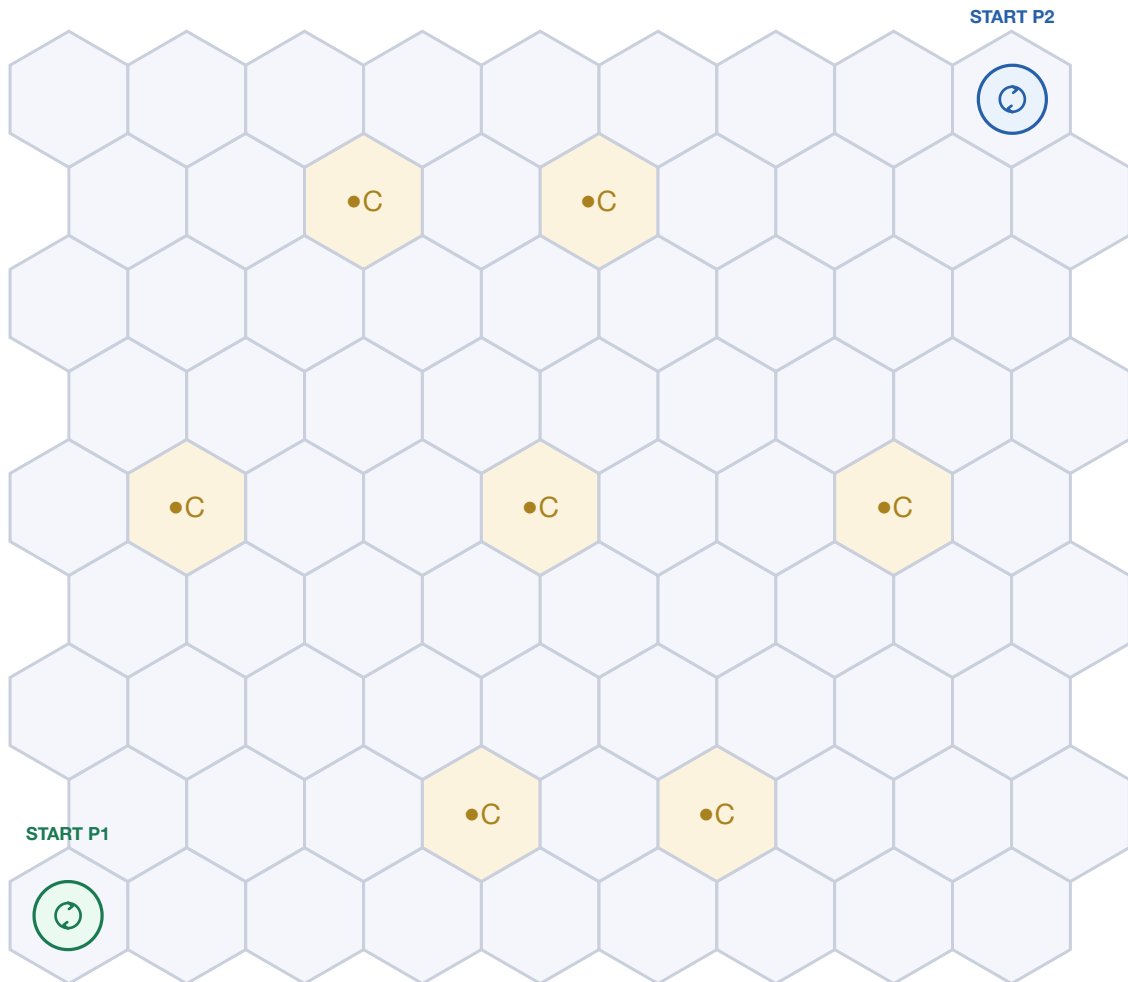


BACKBONE

A network-building strategy game for 2 players

Ages 10+ · roughly 30 minutes · hex board



Player's Guide · Ruleset v1.1 · symmetric board, 10 AI tokens to win

Objective

You are a rival network operator. Expand your infrastructure across the hex map, bring **Datacenters** online, and connect **Cities** to your network. The first player to reach **10 AI tokens** at the end of their turn triggers the endgame — see *Winning the Game* below.

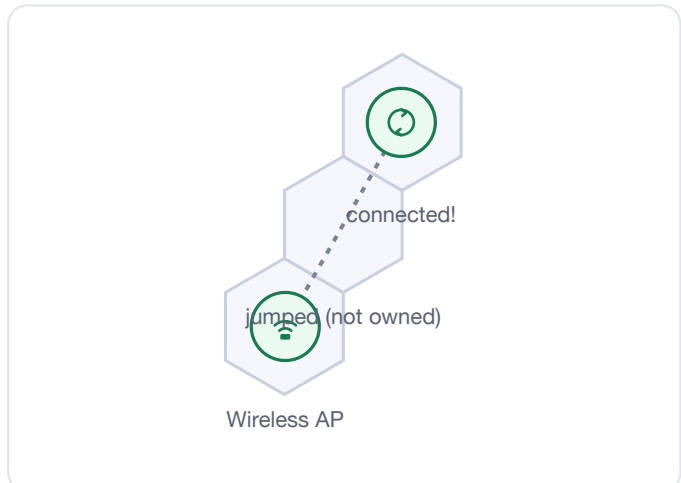
The Board

A 9×9 hex grid. Two corners are **start hexes** — yours already holds a Router and a Server. Seven **City** hexes (●) are neutral, never move, and are shared ground: both players may connect to the same City at once. The city layout is a true 180° rotation of the grid, so both starting corners are exactly the same distance from the nearest, second-nearest, and every other City — nobody has a geometric head start.

Adjacency



Adjacent means the six hexes touching a hex — the highlighted hex and its full ring of neighbors.



A Wireless AP also counts as adjacent to whatever sits exactly 1 hex beyond it in a straight line. The jumped hex itself is never claimed as territory.

Setup

1. Starting pieces

Each player begins with 1 Router and 1 Server on their start corner and the hex next to it.

2. Bandwidth

Player 1 takes 3 BW. Player 2 takes 5 BW — the extra 2 offsets moving second.

3. First move

Player 1 begins.

Bandwidth (BW) is the game's only currency — spent to Build, and to Hack. Income (below) adds more of it every turn, up to a hand limit of 10.

Turn Structure

1. Income

+3 BW, plus +1 BW per City you're currently connected to. Capped at 10 BW.

2. Actions

Take any **2** actions: Build, Hack, or Reroute — the same action twice is fine.

3. Recover

Remove Disabled markers from pieces that were hacked on the opponent's last turn.

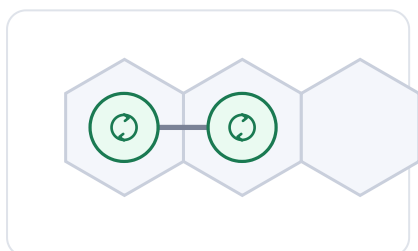
4. Score

Count your AI tokens. Reaching the target here can end the game — see below.

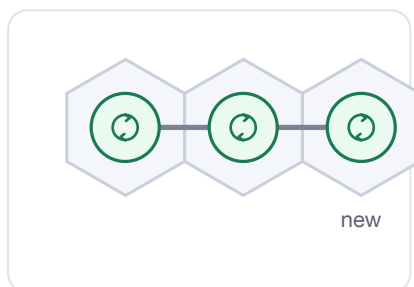
The Three Actions

Build

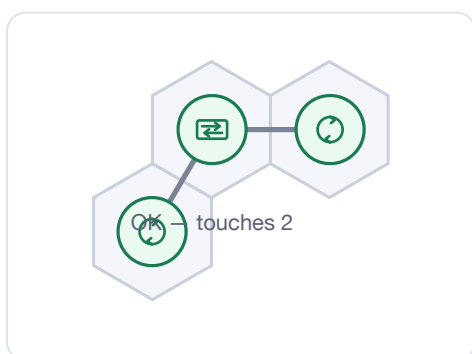
Pay the piece's cost and place it from your supply on an empty, non-City hex adjacent to your network. New pieces must keep your network connected. (Firewalls are the exception — they're placed on top of a piece you already own, not on an empty hex.)



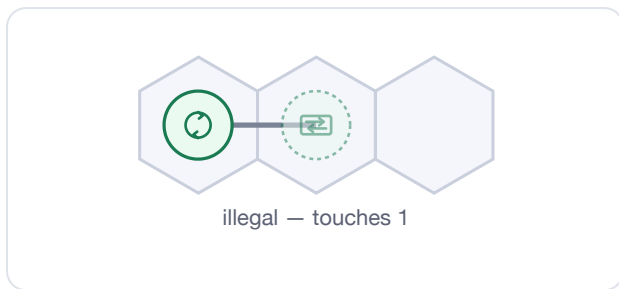
Before: two Routers form the frontier.



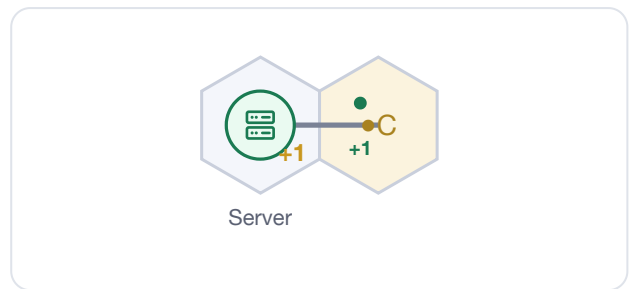
After: a new Router extends the network one hex further — the new hex becomes territory.



A Switch needs 2+ adjacent friendly pieces to be legal — it fills a gap...



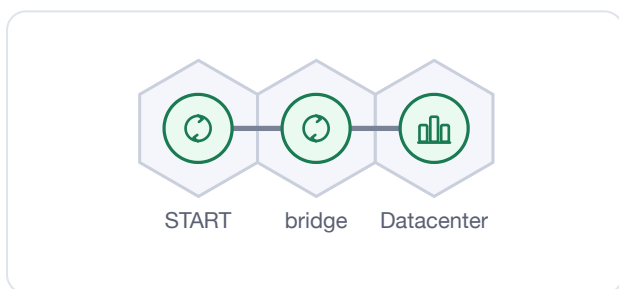
One adjacent piece is not enough. Switches consolidate; they do not expand the frontier on their own.



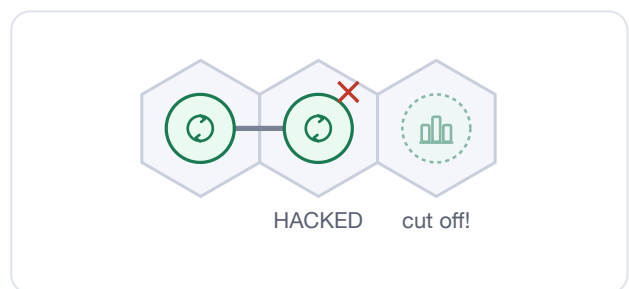
A Server built adjacent to a City connects it — the City shows the connecting player color and starts contributing +1 AI token.

Hack

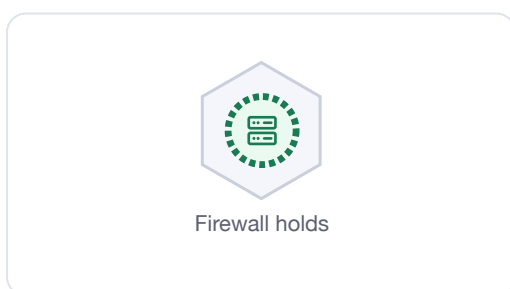
Pay the Hack cost and choose an enemy piece adjacent to your network. If it carries a Firewall, the Firewall is discarded (and returned to its owner's supply) and the piece is safe. Otherwise a Disabled marker goes on it: until it recovers at the end of the victim's next turn, it does not connect, serve, or score — **and any of the victim's pieces that were only reachable through it fall out of the network too**. Hacks never destroy pieces or remove territory outright.



Before: a Router is the sole bridge connecting a Datacenter to the rest of the network.



After a Hack: the bridge Router is disabled, and the Datacenter it was carrying falls out of the network — no longer online, no longer scoring.



A Firewallled piece absorbs the next Hack instead of being disabled — the Firewall is spent in the process.

Defend what matters. The single piece holding two halves of your network together, or the Router propping up a Datacenter, is worth a Firewall far more than a piece on the edge of your territory.

Reroute

Move one of your Switches or Wireless APs to a different legal hex, free of charge. Your network must remain fully connected — at least as large as it was — after the move.

Infrastructure Pieces

Piece	Cost	What it does
 Router	2 BW	The backbone. Extends your network into a new hex and claims it as territory. Datacenters need 2 adjacent Routers to come online.
 Switch	1 BW	Cheap glue. May only be placed adjacent to 2+ of your own pieces — it fills gaps, it never expands the frontier.
 Wireless AP	3 BW	Jumps your connection over exactly 1 hex — empty or enemy-occupied. The jumped hex is not your territory; the AP's own hex is.
 Firewall	2 BW	Placed on top of one of your pieces. Blocks the next Hack against that piece, then is discarded and returns to your supply.
 Server	3 BW	Serves 1 adjacent City (your choice, fixed at build time). Also satisfies the Server requirement for Datacenters in your network.
 Datacenter	6 BW	Your engine of victory. Online — and worth 1 AI token — while adjacent to 2+ of your Routers and connected to 1+ of your Servers.

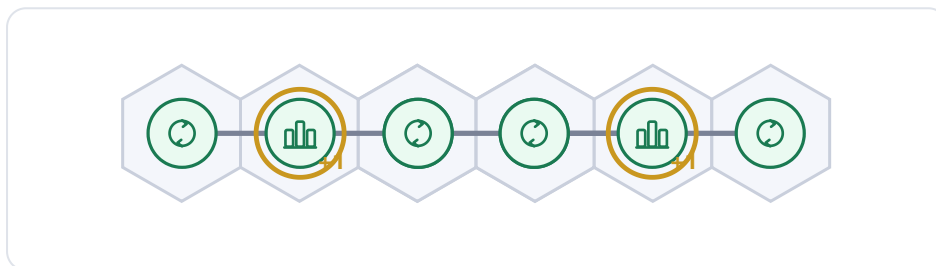
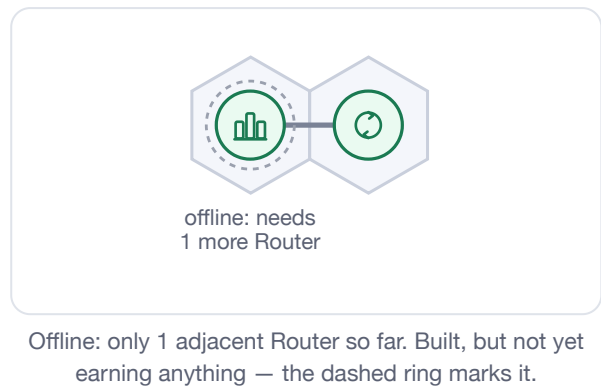
Scoring

Checked at the end of every turn:

Source	AI tokens
Each of your online Datacenter	1
Each City connected to your network	1
Two or more of your Datacenters linked through your network (once, as a bonus)	2



Online: 2 adjacent Routers, and a Server somewhere in the same network. Scores +1 AI token — shown by the gold ring.



Two online Datacenters sharing one network trigger the one-time +2 link bonus — on top of the +1 each already earns for being online.

A Datacenter that isn't online yet is an investment, not points — it takes a turn or two of Router support to start paying off. Losing your only networked Server takes every Datacenter offline at once, not just the City connections — that's usually the more dangerous hack.

Winning the Game

The moment you end a turn with **10 AI tokens or more**, your opponent gets exactly **one more full turn** before the game is scored — a fair chance to catch up or overtake, since by the numbers alone the player who reaches the target first would otherwise win almost automatically. Afterward: whoever holds more AI tokens wins; a tie goes to whoever has more connected Cities; still tied is a draw. (If *you* are the second player to reach the target on that closing turn, the game ends immediately — both sides have already had the same number of turns, so no extra turn is needed.)

If both players are stuck with no productive action for a full round (four consecutive Passes), the game ends the same way: most AI tokens, then more connected Cities, then a draw.

Strategy Tips

- Routers grab ground fast but stretch you thin — a long, unprotected spine is easy to Hack at the joints. Switches and Wireless APs make a denser, harder-to-cut core, at the cost of territory.
- Firewall the pieces whose loss hurts most: the Server feeding a Datacenter, or the single link holding two halves of your network together — not whatever's simply nearest the front line.

- An unbuilt Datacenter is not a Datacenter. Don't celebrate placing one until it actually has 2 Routers and a networked Server — check the ring.
- The two-Datacenter link bonus (+2) is often the sprint that actually ends the game — it's worth planning your network's shape around getting two Datacenters into the same component, not just building them wherever there's room.
- Hacking is limited to once per turn at 1 BW — cheap, but not free. A well-timed single Hack that severs a bridge is worth far more than denying one piece's income.

Quick Reference

Piece	Cost	Piece	Cost
 Router	2 BW	 Firewall	2 BW
 Switch	1 BW	 Server	3 BW
 Wireless AP	3 BW	 Datacenter	6 BW

Rule	Value
AI tokens to win	10 (triggers opponent's final turn)
Income	+3 BW, +1 per connected City, cap 10
Hack cost	1 BW, at most once per turn
Datacenter online	2 adjacent Routers + 1 networked Server
Datacenter link bonus	+2, once, for 2+ online Datacenters in one network
Stuck game	4 consecutive Passes → most AI tokens, then more Cities, then draw